absence of Ahmed Patel, her gatekeeper and sounding board till his death in 2020. His absence has left a huge communication gap has opened up between the Family and party.

Rahul has a more expansive and anonymous feedback mechanism. He regularly receives information from grassroots workers, mid-level leaders and even outsiders. He may reach out to P. Chidambaram on an economic issue or follow the brief of a journalist on the India-China border conflict. Such feedback, though useful, has little political or electoral calculation built into it.

Priyanka is a more instinctive politician who makes a public display of riding pillion on a scooter in Uttar Pradesh or hugging a tea estate worker in Assam. She has no permanent favourites and subscribes to the horses for courses formula. She now aspires to play the same role for Rahul that Patel did for Sonia. It was she who convinced Sonia and Rahul to make Udai Bhan, a loyalist of former Haryana chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, the state Congress president even though the decision went against Rahul's favourite Randeep Singh Surjewala.

Their continuing hold on the party but without any clearly-defined role has given rise to different sets of loyalists for the three Gandhis, causing further division and bickering within the party. Resolving the leadership, therefore, has to be the party's first priority, urge professional advisors within and outside the party, including Kishor, if it is to end the inertia and confusion.

With organisational elections under way, there is strong hope that the party will get a new president in September. Sonia is reluctant due to her health issues. Rahul has expressed no desire so far to be a presidential candidate. He doesn't want Priyanka to contest either, and she is unlikely to go against his wish. Some insiders predict two scenarios—the Family will field a loyalist or the G23 may put up someone of their choice. Congress Leader in the Lok Sabha Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury says the party is not wedded to the idea of only a Gandhi leading the party. "If any capable leader is available who can revive the Congress, the entire party will offer full cooperation. After all, in the past also, leaders like Narasimha Rao have helmed the party," he says.

Where's the party?

Its poor organisational structure is emerging as the biggest weakness of the Congress, something Chidambaram attests to when he says the party is good at governance when it is in power, but functions poorly when in Opposition. As he puts it, "When we run the government, we fail to run the party. Most senior leaders are inducted into the government and not spared for party work. When Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh were prime ministers, we neglected the party organisation. Because the party machinery and work had been neglected, when we are in the Opposition, the party organisation has not picked up the responsibilities or carried the message and the narrative of the party."

And elections, as the BJP and now other regional parties too have successfully demonstrated, are won at the very micro unit—the polling booth. Organisational elections in the Congress have been under way since April 15, right from the booth level. The same exercise had been carried out in 2018 too, as mandated every three years. On paper, such committees—at the booth, block, district and state level—have come into existence.

The problem is that there is no regular system of tracking performance or accountability of the leaders heading the respective organisational structures. The Congress president appoints an AICC (All-India Congress Committee) in-charge in every state. They, in turn, are tasked with monitoring the performance of the state unit, report to the president and take corrective measures whenever needed. The in-charges are expected to spend most of their time in the states they are handling. The reality is anything but. The BJP, on the other hand, operates like a corporate entity, demanding accountability from its party leaders and removing them if they are found wanting.

MOST CONGRESS LEADERS SAY THE PARTY'S INERTIA COMES FROM ITS CULTURE OF CONSENSUS BUILDING

The Congress is also talking of generational change in leadership. Fifty per cent of the delegates at its Chintan Shivir will be leaders under the age of 50. Chidambaram believes all posts at the block, district and state level must also be manned by people under 50. Manickam Tagore, a Lok Sabha member from Tamil Nadu and in-charge of Telangana, says the decision-making process in the party should involve those whose future is at stake and not those who are past their prime. This was top of the list in Kishor's prescription too—all leaders above the age of 70 step aside.

What's the message?

It's not just a dearth of next-gen leaders but also the absence of a cohesive counter-narrative against the BJP and other regional parties that has contributed to the party's electoral distress. The BJP has nearly perfected its discourse around the politics of Hindutva, muscular nationalism and the *labharthi*s (beneficiaries). The Congress response has been ad